(Shomerei Sephardim, the guardians of Sephardim); his anointed disciple and successor was Aryeh Deri. Shas is strictly religious and right-wing, and it still somehow thinks in terms of the traditional hostility against Ashkenazim (although Netanyahu is as Ashkenazi as can be). Nonetheless, Deri and Bibi (Netanyahu's common nickname) have one major trait in common: both have been or are being indicted, the first for tax evasion, the second on three counts of corruption.

And Shas isn't the worst by any means. The new coalition includes truly abhorrent specimens: Bezalel Smotrich and his Religious Zionist Party; and Itamar Ben-Gvir, a former Rabbi Kahane disciple, and his Jewish Power contingent. I am sure that they will be quite prominent in the following pages.

A major difference between the Israeli right-wing coalition and run-of-the-mill authoritarian governments in power nowadays is the role of the army. Usually, the army supports a national authoritarian government. In present-day Israel, the army—including its boss, the Likud defense minister Yoav Gallant—have clearly indicated that all matters pertaining to the occupied Palestinian territories will remain its exclusive domain. Smotrich, the extreme right-wing ideologist whom Netanyahu appointed as finance minister and minister in the Defense Department in charge of civilian matters in Judea and Samaria—in other words, responsible for settlements and settlers in the Occupied Territories—was blocked by Gallant from interfering in the first case he instigated: the establishment of the new settlement Or Haim. Netanyahu had no choice but to support Gallant, probably nudged by his own Likud party and, some contend, by the White House … In his protest to the prime minister, Smotrich was joined by Ben-Gvir, but to no avail.

All of this does not turn the Israeli army into a fortress of legality; it is the melting pot of a multiethnic society, with the exception of its ultrareligious segment (to which I shall return presently). In that sense it is a